

view)—the voters' verdict will be known on March 10.

There's room for suspense there. A few months ago, the BJP may have been justified in believing it had the UP 2022 poll firmly sewed up. After all, it had all the heavy artillery—a formidable party infrastructure, a purpose-filled government that was now skilfully bilingual in the languages of identity as well as development, and a triumvirate of charismatic Hindutva mascots. But the churn of heartland politics can hold surprises. For, not far from Adityanath's official residence, his predecessor and arch rival Akhilesh Yadav, the youthful Samajwadi Party (SP) chief, has plotted a determined comeback.

MAYAWATI HAD LINKED UP DALITS, MUSLIMS AND BRAHMINS TO WIN A MAJORITY IN 2007. THAT ALLIANCE HAS MOSTLY ERODED, BUT ADHERENTS FEEL SHE WILL STILL BE THE KINGMAKER AFTER MARCH 10

IF THE COUNT OF VEHICLES flocking the SP's sprawling headquarters (it even has an amphitheatre) are any indication of voting intentions, you could be pardoned for thinking the SP is winning hands down! It may just be the thrum of a more earthy politics though. As a political observer explains, unlike the BJP, which has a disciplined cadre and party structure, SP supporters are often uncontrollable and the party apparatus disorganised. Especially because Akhilesh is virtually a one-man army and every ticket-seeker, with his comet's tail of flunkies, makes it a point to seek "netaji's" blessings.

The five years Akhilesh spent on the Opposition benches after his party was trounced by the BJP in 2017 saw him mature into a wiser, cannier politician—though one who still retains his youthful mien and exuberance. Wearing his party's signature red cap, the 48-year-old Akhilesh told INDIA TODAY, "In the last five years, I realised that one should stay focused on the development vision. The BJP is only cutting ribbons of the projects we started in my tenure as chief minister." Before the Election Commission clamped down on campaign rallies because of the Covid threat, Akhilesh had set out on a series of yatras across the state, focusing on the failures of the 'Yogi Sarkar' and drawing large crowds. When he chanted his favourite campaign slogan, "2022 *mein badlav hoga. Janta ne mann bana liya hai, is sarkar ko ukhaad phenkne ka* (2022 will bring change, the people are determined to throw this government out)," the crowd would roar back, "*Sarkar ko ukhaad phenkne ka*."

Then, in the last fortnight, Akhilesh shook the ruling BJP when he got two prominent members of Adityanath's cabinet, Swami Prasad Maurya and Dara Singh Chauhan, and a minister of state, Dharam Singh Saini, to resign from their posts and join the SP. All three belonged to UP's vast cartography of backward classes—tending to the Extreme Backward Class (EBC) part of the spectrum—and came out complaining that the BJP had neglected their community interests and that Adityanath had taken decisions involving their ministries without consulting them. In winning them over to his side, Akhilesh had taken a leaf out of the BJP's UP playbook of 2017 and used it against them. Prior to 2017, the BJP, seen as predominantly a party of the upper castes, had gone about aggressively wooing the larger backward class constituency, building a narrative that Akhilesh as CM had